

Out of the Game

Six scenes from the ordinary life of a couple.

What really happens — and how to start doing things differently.

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Introduction

What You Will Find Here — and What You Won't

There is one thing that most books about relationships don't say plainly.

When we're hurting in a relationship, we rarely arrive with a neutral view of what's happening. We arrive with our own pain, our own exhaustion, our own version of the story. And that version — even when it's sincere, even when it's legitimate — is a lens. It illuminates certain things, and leaves others in the shadow.

This booklet starts from there.

What It Is

A tool for awareness. Not therapy. Not a diagnosis. Not a way to prove you're right — or that the other person is wrong.

It offers six scenes from the ordinary life of a couple. Scenes that everyone recognizes, precisely because they're mundane. And for each scene, an invitation to look at what's really happening — in the dynamic, in the roles, in what each person finds there without admitting it to themselves.

The theoretical framework used is Transactional Analysis — ego states, psychological games, the Karpman Drama Triangle. You don't need to know these concepts to use this booklet. They are explained as the scenes unfold, in the context where they appear.

What It Is Not

This booklet is not couples therapy. It doesn't replace individual or joint support from a professional. If what you're going through is deep, painful, or has been going on for a long time — what you'll find here can be a starting point. Not a complete solution.

It's also not a tool to convince the other person. If you use it to show them "what they do," you'll have missed the point entirely. This booklet is first and foremost a mirror — and mirrors look both ways.

The Most Important Thing to Understand Before Starting

Imagine the following scene.

She criticizes him for never talking about what he feels. He closes off a little more with each criticism. She criticizes more, because he closes off. He closes off more, because she criticizes.

Who started it? The question has no answer — because it's not the right question. What's happening here is not a fault. It's a loop. And in a loop, there is no one to blame — there are two people feeding the same system, each in their own way, without seeing it.

That is what a psychological game is. Both play. Always.

It's not intuitive — especially when you're hurting. When you're exhausted, when you're carrying what should be shared, when you feel like you're making efforts the other person isn't making — the natural view is asymmetric. You see what the other person does. You see much less clearly what you yourself do to keep it going.

It's not bad faith. It's mechanical. Pain, mental load, distress direct your attention toward what hurts — not toward what you're contributing.

This booklet doesn't ask you to minimize what you're experiencing. It asks something more useful: to understand how you participate in what keeps repeating. Not to burden yourself. Because it's the only place from which you can truly act.

How to Use This Booklet

Solo. This is the most natural way to start. You read the scenes, note what you recognize, do the daily tracking. Without the other person knowing, without talking about it. The work happens inside you first — and it produces effects in the relationship, often without needing to be explained.

Together. If your partner is open to exploring this with you, each scene offers a version for two — a short, structured conversation, outside moments of tension. This is not

improvised couples therapy. It's a way of looking together at what you usually look at separately.

With a guide. If you already work with a coach or therapist, this booklet can serve as support between sessions — to observe, note, and bring something concrete to what you're exploring together.

One last thing.

The scenes you're about to read are intentionally ordinary. Nothing dramatic. Nothing exceptional. These are the moments nobody notices — precisely because they repeat.

That's where the games live. And that's where we can begin to see them.

For Aydan, who helped me grow, which allows me to offer you these experiences

Scene 1 — Household Tasks

"The Wooden Leg"

The Scene

Kitchen, evening. She's loading the dishwasher, he's sitting in the living room.

Her: "Can you put a load of laundry on?"

He comes into the kitchen, looks at the machine.

Him: "Uh... which setting was it again?"

She sighs, steps forward.

Her: "Never mind, I'll do it."

He goes back to the living room. She stands in front of the machine, face closed.

Later in the evening.

Her: "You could at least make an effort."

Him: "Last time I tried to help, you went back and redid everything. So what's the point."

Silence. Each on their own.

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one who asks · the one who "doesn't know" · both depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you're reading this booklet, it's probably because something isn't working. Because you're tired of carrying more than your share. Because you feel that no matter what you do, it's never good enough. Because the same arguments keep coming back — about the same topics, with the same words — and you no longer really know how to get out of them.

What you feel is real. The exhaustion is real. The frustration is real. This booklet is not going to tell you that you're wrong to feel them.

But it will offer you something a little uncomfortable: to also look at what's happening on your side. Not to make you feel guilty. Not to say you're just as wrong as the other person. But because it's the only place from which you can truly change something.

We can't change the other person. We can change what we do — and observe how the system reconfigures.

That's all this booklet asks of you.

What's Really Happening

The scene you just read, you may have lived dozens of times. The details change — the washing machine, the dishes, the groceries, the bathroom. But the structure stays the same. One asks. The other doesn't know, or pretends not to know. One takes over. The other leaves. And in the evening, something heavy floats in the air without anyone quite knowing what to do with it.

What's happening on the surface looks like an organizational problem. Who does what. Who knows what. What's really happening is different.

A system has settled in — gradually, without anyone having decided it. Like all systems, it has its own logic. It sustains itself. And it costs enormously — not in energy spent on the tasks, but in resentment that accumulates, in distance that settles, in the image of the other that slowly distorts.

This isn't an argument about laundry. It's an argument about who is responsible for what in this relationship — and what that says about each person.

What Each Person Is Really Living

Let's start with her — because if you recognize yourself in this role, you deserve to have what you're really carrying named.

Managing the home largely alone is exhausting. Not just physically. It's the mental load — that permanent list in your head of what still needs to be done, what's going to run out, what you'll need to remember to organize. A list no one else carries. And when you finally ask for help, you get a blank look in front of the washing machine — a machine that's been running in this apartment for years.

What you feel there isn't a bad mood. It's deep exhaustion. And something that looks like loneliness.

Now, him.

If you recognize yourself in the other role — the one who "doesn't know," the one who goes back to the living room — you might know this feeling: whatever you do, it's always redone, corrected, fixed. You load the dishwasher, she reorganizes the glasses. You fold the laundry, she refolds the piles. You try to do the right thing — and the message you receive, without anyone saying it in words, is that it's not enough. That your way of doing things isn't the right way.

At some point, you stop trying. Not out of laziness. Out of discouragement.

Both of these experiences are real. Both are legitimate. And both feed the same system — without either person having wanted it.

The Game Being Played — Without Anyone Having Decided It

In psychology, this is called a game — not in the fun sense, but in the sense of a scenario that repeats itself, with fixed roles, and always the same conclusion. A game where everyone loses, but where everyone keeps playing anyway.

This one is called "The Wooden Leg" — and it looks like this.

There are three roles in this game. The **Victim** — the one who suffers, who can't, who is overwhelmed. The **Rescuer** — the one who takes charge, who fixes, who does it instead. And the **Persecutor** — the one who accuses, who criticizes, who judges.

What makes this game insidious is that the roles shift. Watch how it plays out in the scene.

She arrives with a request — "*can you put a load on?*" But that request isn't neutral. It comes after several times it hasn't been done. It already carries, silently, the expectation of failure. That's the position of the **Persecutor in waiting** — not out of malice, but because the history between them has already written the next chapter.

He senses it. Not consciously. But he senses that whatever he does, it probably won't be good enough. So he enters as the **Victim** — "*I don't know how*" is a way of saying "*I'd rather not try than try and fail.*"

She takes over. She becomes the **Rescuer** — she solves, she does it, she keeps the home running. And he goes back to the living room — a relieved **Victim**, who has avoided the criticism.

Then in the evening, she criticizes. She shifts to **Persecutor**. And he plays his trump card — "*last time I tried to help, you went back and redid everything.*" He's right. And that fact places her, momentarily, as the **Victim** of her own way of doing things.

She's trapped. He's trapped. And tomorrow, the same scene will start again.

What Each Person Gets from It — the Hard Part to Read

This is the most uncomfortable section. The one where you might feel like closing this booklet.

Because this system persists not because one is lazy and the other courageous. It persists because it's useful — not consciously, not deliberately, but really — to both of them.

For her. Carrying everything gives something. It's not just a burden — it's also a position. The position of the one who knows, who acts, who holds things together. A form of control over the space and over how things are done. And sometimes something deeper: the conviction that if she lets go, everything falls apart. That her value in this relationship partly depends on what she does for him.

It's not her fault. It's often something learned very early — that taking care of others is what makes us loveable.

For him. Not knowing protects something. If I don't do it, I can't do it wrong. If I give up quickly, she takes over — and I avoid being evaluated. This strategy has a history too. Somewhere, at some point, not trying was less painful than trying and being corrected.

Reading this might create resistance. That's normal. It's not an accusation — it's an invitation to look honestly at what this system gives you, right now. Because as long as we don't see what we get from it, we don't really understand why we keep playing.

The "Done Right" Trap — A Word for the One Who Takes Over

There is something specific worth naming — because it's often invisible to the person who does it.

When you've been managing the home for a long time, you develop a way of doing things. An organizational logic that works, that's efficient, that has proven itself. Laundry sorted in a certain way. The dishwasher loaded in a certain order. Groceries

listed according to a certain system.

This isn't arbitrary perfectionism. It's accumulated experience.

The problem is that this way of doing things becomes an implicit standard — never really articulated, never really shared. And when the other person tries, in their own way, with their own habits — and the result doesn't match that standard — something triggers. A sigh. A quiet correction. A quick redo — "*never mind, I'll redo it.*"

That gesture — even done with no intention of hurting — sends a very clear message to the other person: *what you do isn't good enough.*

And the other person, who did try, takes note. Next time, they'll try less. Then not at all. And you find yourself complaining that they do nothing — when you, without meaning to, trained them not to.

A question worth asking honestly:

Am I redoing this because it's truly necessary — or because it wasn't done the way I would have done it?

Those two reasons aren't the same thing. The first is a question of outcome — something isn't working, it needs correcting. The second is a question of preference. And preferences can be negotiated.

What if you left the laundry folded differently — but folded? What if you left the kitchen tidied according to his logic — not yours, but a logic nonetheless?

What would that truly change? And what would it free up — for you, for him, for both of you?

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

When we're hurting in this scene, the natural reflex is to think the problem comes from the other person. That they don't do enough. That they don't understand. That they need to change.

This reflex is human. And it has a cost: as long as we wait for the other person to change before feeling better, we give them all the power over our state. We put ourselves in dependency.

NVC (Nonviolent Communication) offers something different — and more demanding. It starts from the principle that my needs belong to me. They are not a consequence of what the other person does or doesn't do. And I am responsible for finding how to meet them.

It's not *"I need you to do your share"* — that's a demand disguised as a need. It's *"I need efficiency — and here's how I choose to meet it."*

The difference is enormous. In the first case, I'm waiting. In the second, I'm moving.

Exercise — Identifying Your Deep Need

Read the following list. For each need, the question isn't "is the other person preventing me from having it?" but "is this need alive in me — and how do I choose to meet it?"

Check the two or three that truly resonate.

Need	What it means for me
Efficiency	I like things done in a way that costs me little energy and leaves me available for other things
Order	An organized space lets me feel well and think clearly
Lightness	I need to have energy available at the end of the day — for myself, for us
Intimacy	What I do in the home, I sometimes choose to free up time for what truly nourishes the connection
Mental space	When things are in order, my mind is free for other things
Autonomy	I like to decide how I contribute — in my own way, according to my own priorities
Security	A home that functions gives me a feeling of stability that I need
Creativity	Some household tasks are an expressive space for me — cooking, decorating, organizing
Contribution	Participating in the shared home has meaning for me — it's a way of caring for what belongs to us
Energy	What I do or don't do in the home is also energy management — I choose where I put it

Once your needs are identified, complete this sentence for each:

"I need ___. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is ___."

A few examples to get you started:

"I need efficiency. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is take charge of the tasks I do quickly and well — and let go of the ones that aren't a priority for me."

"I need intimacy. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is finish quickly what needs to be done tonight — so I have time and energy to be truly present with the other person."

"I need mental space. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is write down the tasks somewhere so I'm no longer carrying them in my head."

What you often observe after this exercise: the frustration toward the other person diminishes. Not because the distribution problem has been solved — but because you've reclaimed something. You're no longer waiting. You're moving.

The Exits

Exit 1 — Notice your role in the moment

The next time this scene is triggered, one internal question — quick, without analysis:

Right now, am I more in the mode of rescuing, accusing, or suffering?

No need for an elaborate answer. Just name it. This recognition creates a space — even a tiny one — between what's happening and what you do.

If you're **rescuing** — taking over before the other person has finished, redoing what was done — pause. One question: *is this truly necessary, or is it simply not the way I would have done it?* If it's the second reason: let it go. This time.

If you're **suffering** — not trying, waiting for the other to take over — pause too. *Do I really not know how — or have I learned that trying was pointless?* If it's the second reason: one attempt. Imperfect. But one attempt.

Exit 2 — The Letting Go Experience (solo exercise)

This exercise is for the one who takes over. It requires a little courage.

This week, choose one task — just one — that you truly delegate. Not by explaining how to do it. Not by checking afterward. Just: *"can you take care of this this week?"* And let go.

It doesn't matter if it's done differently. It doesn't matter if it's not exactly as you would have done it.

And note three things:

"What was done is..." — name what was accomplished. Truly accomplished. Not what's missing.

"*What this freed up for me was...*" — what were you able to do, or not do, during that time? Rest? A moment for yourself? Just breathe?

"*What I wanted to correct but let go was...*" — note the resistance. Without acting on it. Just observe it.

The goal is not to accept disorder forever. It's to see, just once, what control costs — and what letting go gives.

Exit 3 — Reconnect to your need (solo)

The next time frustration builds in this scene, before saying anything — an internal pause.

Go back to your list of identified needs above. And complete mentally:

"*Right now, the need that's activated in me is _____. And what I choose to do to meet it is _____.*"

This shift — even done silently, even in thirty seconds — changes something. You move from reaction to choice.

Exit 4 — Move from criticism to need (together)

If you want to talk to the other person — and only if the moment is calm, not right after a tension — a different way to open the conversation.

Instead of: "*you never do anything, it's always me doing everything.*"

Try: "*I realized something. What exhausts me most isn't the tasks themselves — it's having them all in my head constantly. Can we figure out together how to lighten that?*"

It's not the same conversation. The first is an accusation — it calls for a defense. The

second is an invitation — it can call for a response.

Exit 5 — Build something together (together)

A conversation to have calmly, an evening when you're not exhausted. Twenty minutes.

Not to decide who does what on a chart. To understand what really matters to each of you — and build something from there.

A few questions to get started:

"In our home, what truly matters to you — and what matters less?"

"What do you prefer doing — and what do you find truly unpleasant?"

"How can we organize ourselves in a way that respects what matters to each of us?"

And an implicit rule to set together, if possible: what's delegated belongs to the person doing it. Their way. Not yours. The result is what matters — not the path to get there.

Feeding Your Free Child — A Practice in Its Own Right

There is something this booklet will repeat in every scene — because it's one of the simplest and least used keys.

When we're exhausted, when we're carrying too much, when we're controlling because we feel that if we let go everything falls apart — it's often a sign that we've forgotten to nourish ourselves.

In psychology, we talk about the Free Child — that part of you that plays, creates, feels, has fun without ulterior motives. The part that existed before you learned to be useful, responsible, reasonable. It hasn't disappeared. It's just waiting for a little space.

And here's what's interesting: when the Free Child is nourished, the need to control diminishes naturally. Not because you've decided to let go — but because you need to hold on less. You're less tense, less watchful, less inclined to redo. You have more energy to be truly present — for yourself and for the other person.

Some examples of what nourishes the Free Child:

Doing something creative without a goal — drawing, cooking for pleasure, gardening, tinkering. Moving for the pleasure of it — dancing, walking without a destination, swimming. Learning something just because it's interesting — not useful, not productive, just curious. Playing — a game, an instrument, a sport, anything that has no goal other than the pleasure of playing. Resting truly — not recovering to produce better afterward. Resting because you feel like it. Doing something spontaneous — without planning, without optimizing, just because the urge is there.

Free Child Tracker — 7 days

Every evening, one minute. Not a review — just note.

Day	What I did for my Free Child	How I felt afterward	Did it change something about my evening?
Monday			yes · a little · no
Tuesday			yes · a little · no
Wednesday			yes · a little · no
Thursday			yes · a little · no
Friday			yes · a little · no
Saturday			yes · a little · no
Sunday			yes · a little · no

The end-of-week question:

On the days when I nourished my Free Child — did I have more or less urge to control, redo, carry? Is there a connection?

Daily Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, two minutes.

Day	I took over a task without letting the other finish	I left something done "differently" without correcting	I expressed a need instead of a criticism
Monday	☐	☐	☐
Tuesday	☐	☐	☐
Wednesday	☐	☐	☐
Thursday	☐	☐	☐
Friday	☐	☐	☐
Saturday	☐	☐	☐
Sunday	☐	☐	☐

One question per evening — not all at once, just the one for that day:

Monday: *Today, in this scene, was I more in the mode of rescuing, accusing, or suffering?*

Tuesday: *What did I avoid feeling by taking over — or by giving up?*

Wednesday: *What need was activated today — and how did I choose to meet it?*

Thursday: *What would have happened if I'd done things differently — just once?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change, even slightly?*

Saturday: *What am I confirming about the other person by repeating this system — and is that really true?*

Sunday: *What do I want to keep from this week — and what do I want to see differently next week?*

If You Want to Explore This Together

To do calmly — not after an argument, not exhausted at the end of the evening. A moment when you're both available. Twenty minutes.

Part 1 — What Each Person Is Really Living (10 minutes)

Each person takes a sheet and completes these sentences alone, without showing the other:

"In the way we manage our home, what truly exhausts me is..."

"The need I'm trying to meet when I handle things the way I do is..."

"What I find hard to say about this is..."

Then you share. Each person reads what they wrote. The other listens — without interrupting, without defending, without explaining. Just hear.

This is not a debate. It's two people showing each other something true.

Part 2 — An Agreement That Respects Both (10 minutes)

One question to explore together:

"How do we organize ourselves in a way that nourishes what matters to each of us — and leaves us both energy for something other than tasks?"

Not a chore list. A living agreement — that can be adjusted, revised, tested. With one rule: what's delegated belongs to the person doing it. Their way. Not the other's.

*The next scene takes place at the apartment entrance. It's 8:30 pm.
She hasn't said anything yet — and yet something has already
begun.*

Scene 2 — The Late Return

"Tell Me I Matter"

The Scene

Apartment entrance, 8:30 pm. He comes in, visibly tired. She's in the kitchen, back turned.

Him: "Evening. Sorry, meeting that went on forever."

Silence. She continues what she was doing.

Her: "You just don't care, that's all."

Him: "What? I had a terrible day."

Her: "So did I."

He puts his things down, exhales.

Him: "You want to argue, is that it?"

She doesn't answer. Dinner passes without them really looking at each other.

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one coming home · the one who waited · both
depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you recognize yourself in this scene, it's probably because you've lived it. Not exactly like this — the words change, the time changes. But that evening, that silence, that dinner where nobody really looks at each other — you know what that's like.

And if you're the one who waited, you also know what it's like to spend the evening managing, organizing, holding things together — and to see the other person come home without seeming to grasp what that represents. The frustration building. The criticism coming out — not always in the form you would have wanted.

What you feel is real. It's not a bad mood. It's not irrational.

But this booklet will offer you something a little uncomfortable: to also look at what's happening on your side. Not to minimize what you're going through. Not to say you're wrong. But because it's the only place from which you can truly change something.

We can't change the other person. We can change what we do — and observe how the evening reconfigures.

What's Really Happening

The scene you just read is not an argument about work schedules. What's happening here has almost nothing to do with the meeting that went on forever.

While she waited, something built up. She managed the evening, the children perhaps, dinner, the ordinary mental load of a weekday night. And alongside that, without really choosing it, an accumulation happened. Not clear thoughts — more something diffuse. Uncertainty about what time he'd be home. The feeling of carrying things alone. And something deeper looking for a form.

When the door opens, that something looks for a way out. And it comes out the way it knows.

"You just don't care, that's all."

That's not really what she wanted to say. Put clearly, it would sound more like: *"I needed you tonight, and once again I didn't know what time you'd be home."* But that sentence is too vulnerable. So it arrives dressed as a criticism.

And the criticism calls for a defense. And the defense confirms what she feared.

On his side, he comes home exhausted. He didn't choose to come home late. He had a bad day. And the first thing he finds when he walks in is an accusation. He also needs something tonight — to be welcomed, to be seen, to breathe. But those needs won't be spoken either.

Both are right about what they're experiencing. Neither is saying what they're really experiencing.

The Game Being Played — Without Anyone Having Decided It

There are three roles in this game. The **Victim** — the one who suffers, who waits, who carries. The **Persecutor** — the one who accuses, who criticizes. And the **Rescuer** — the one who patches things up, who smooths things over, who acts as if.

What's particularly tricky about this scene is that the game begins *before the door even opens*.

While waiting, she gradually slides into the **Victim** position — alone, uncertain, carrying what could have been shared. This slide is not conscious. It's the situation that leads her there.

When he comes home, she shifts into **Persecutor** — the criticism comes out, the accusation arrives. He enters as **Victim** — he's on the receiving end, he justifies himself, he didn't choose to come home late.

Then the twist. "You want to argue?" — he shifts to **Persecutor**, and she becomes the

Victim of the conflict she herself triggered. The silent dinner is the logical conclusion: both have lost, both have confirmed what they feared.

What's revealing: she was in **Victim** mode before he said a word. The rumination during the wait was already the beginning of the game. Before he came home. Before he spoke.

Victim waiting → **Persecutor** on arrival → Defensive **Victim** → **Persecutor** closing off → silence → both confirm what they feared

What Each Person Gets from It — the Hard Part

This system persists because it confirms something for each person.

For her: "*he puts work before us.*" Every late return, every justification, every silent dinner feeds this conviction. And this conviction justifies the next criticism.

For him: "*whatever I do, it's never enough.*" Every criticism, even when he's exhausted and acting in good faith, confirms that coming home is a minefield. And this conviction justifies the withdrawal — which will fuel the next criticism.

Both avoid the same thing — a real conversation about what each needs. And this avoidance slowly digs the distance that neither wants.

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

Before going further, one important point.

In this scene, the two protagonists are not in the same position — and they don't have the same needs. Mixing them means missing something essential.

What follows offers two separate readings. Not to identify a guilty party and a victim. To allow each person to honestly recognize what's activated in them — and find their own exit.

And in both cases, the same rule applies: a need belongs to me. It doesn't depend on what the other person does or doesn't do. I am responsible for finding how to meet it — not for waiting for the other person to guess.

If you're the one who waited

What you express through the criticism isn't really anger about the other person's schedule. It's information about what matters to you — and about what erodes when the evenings all look the same.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Connection	I need moments of real presence — not just coexisting, but truly being together
Intimacy	I need moments that belong to us, different from the daily routine
Fun	I need lightness, laughter, moments that serve no purpose other than feeling good
Sharing	I need us to tell each other about our days, our thoughts, what's moving through us
Vitality	I need our shared life to have momentum — not just management
Adventure	I need us to step outside our habits sometimes — even in small ways
Presence	I need that when we're together, we're truly there — not half elsewhere

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need connection. What I choose to do is propose one evening a week that's just for us — not necessarily anything big, just the two of us without screens."

"I need fun. What I choose to do is suggest something spontaneous this weekend — not over-plan, just suggest."

"I need intimacy. What I choose to do is clearly say what I'd like — rather than hoping the other person will guess."

If you're the one who came home

What you're experiencing when coming home late and tired isn't indifference. It's often exhaustion. And exhaustion has its own needs — that deserve to be named, not silenced.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Space	I need a few minutes to come back to myself before being available for the other person
Empathy	I need what I've been through to be heard — not minimized, not compared
Gentleness	I need a welcome that isn't an evaluation of my return
Recovery	I need to breathe before I can be truly present
Being heard	I need to be able to say how my day went — without it turning into a debate

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need space. What I choose to do is say when I get home — one sentence, not an explanation — that I need ten minutes before being there."

"I need empathy. What I choose to do is ask the other person to hear me for two minutes about my day before we move on to anything else."

"I need gentleness. What I choose to do is name what I need when I get home — rather than waiting for the atmosphere to give it to me or not."

The Decompression Buffer — A Simple and Underrated Idea

There is something concrete that many couples have never really established — not because it's complicated, but because nobody talked about it.

It's the buffer.

A short moment — five, ten minutes — between the front door and the shared evening. Not to ignore each other. To come back to yourself before coming back to the other person.

For the one coming home: put things down, breathe, change. Not to disappear — to truly arrive.

For the one who waited: leave this moment free of expectation, free of questions, free of tension. Not out of resignation — by choice. Because the other person who arrives truly is better than the other person who arrives as a facade.

This buffer isn't a luxury. It's a condition for the evening to begin differently than with a collision.

The Belief That Complicates Everything — "It Should Be Spontaneous"

There is an implicit conviction in many couples that causes enormous damage without ever being named.

It looks like this: *setting a framework, planning moments, making explicit what we need — that means admitting something isn't working anymore. A real couple doesn't need all that. It should come naturally.*

This conviction is beautiful. And it's false.

Or rather — it might describe the first months of a relationship, when everything is new

and the other person occupies all your attention. But over time, in the fatigue of full weeks, in the routine that settles in — waiting for it to come naturally is waiting for the other person to guess. And nobody truly guesses. Not sustainably.

What creates connection over time is often the opposite of spontaneity: it's decision. Deciding that tonight, we're together. Deciding to say what we'd like. Deciding not to let the week decide for us.

This isn't killing spontaneity. It's creating the conditions for it to exist.

Saying What Matters — a Dance, Not a Schedule

What's missing in this scene — and in many evenings like it — is a simple agreement on what matters to each person.

Not a list of rules. Not a planning chart. A conversation.

"Tonight I felt like doing this. Is it possible — or is it tomorrow?"

That sentence changes everything. It says what you'd like without demanding it. It leaves the other person free to respond. It opens a negotiation that isn't a conflict — it's a way of finding each other.

And when both know what matte

The Alert Not to Miss

The exit from this game isn't to come home earlier — or to criticize less.

Coming home earlier without changing the dynamic produces the same scene in a different context. And holding back the criticism without addressing the real need creates a pressure that ends up exploding elsewhere.

What changes something is the shift: from "what do I want the other person to do" to "*what do I need to nourish tonight — and how do I nourish it?*"

The Exits

Exit 1 — Notice your role in the moment

The next time this scene is triggered — or when you sense it approaching — one internal question:

Right now, am I more in the mode of waiting, accusing, or defending?

Just name it. Not analyze. Naming creates a space between reflex and reaction.

If you're **waiting**: what exactly are you waiting for — and can you ask for it directly rather than hoping?

If you're **accusing**: what's really activated — tonight's frustration, or something that's been building for longer?

If you're **defending**: what did you need to find when you got home — and can you say it?

Exit 2 — Say what you need before the evening begins (solo)

This exercise requires a little anticipation.

Before the other person comes home — or before coming home yourself — one internal question:

Tonight, what do I truly need?

Not a list. One thing. The most honest one.

Then try to express it simply, without criticism, before the tension builds. A few example formulations to adapt:

"Tonight I need us to be truly together — not on our phones. Can we do that?"

"I had a hard day. I need 10 minutes to breathe before I'm truly available."

"I needed to know what time you'd be home. Next time, could you send a message?"

These sentences don't fix everything. But they say something true — and they leave the other person the possibility of responding rather than defending.

Exit 3 — Reconnect to your need in the moment (solo)

When tension builds, when the criticism arrives or when the urge to withdraw is strong — pause. Ten seconds.

Complete mentally:

"The need that's activated in me right now is ___. And something I can do to meet it tonight is ___."

Not to erase the frustration. To choose what to do with it.

Exit 4 — The calm conversation (together)

To have outside the moment of tension — not the night of the late return, not during the silent dinner. The next day, calmly, 20 minutes.

Each person completes these sentences separately, in writing:

"When this scene happens, what's activated in me is..."

"The real need behind my reaction is..."

"What I would need from the other person in these moments — not that they change, but..."

Then you share — each person reads, the other listens without interrupting. The goal is not to convince each other. It's to hear what the other person is truly experiencing beneath the surface.

Then, one question to explore together:

"What could we do — a concrete, simple, realistic gesture — so that these evenings go differently?"

Not a solemn commitment. An experiment. That can be adjusted, revisited, abandoned if it doesn't work.

Feeding Your Free Child — Reminder

As in the previous scene — and in all the ones that follow — there is something playing in the background of this dynamic.

When we're exhausted, when we're waiting for the other person to fill something, when we come home on our knees with no resource to be present — it's often a sign that we've forgotten ourselves somewhere in the day.

The Free Child is that part of you that has its own desires, that nourishes itself on simple things — a moment alone, an activity that restores you, something that exists just for you. When it's nourished, the waiting for the other person diminishes naturally. You arrive less empty, less demanding, less on the edge.

The question to ask yourself tonight:

What did I do today — even five minutes — just for myself?

Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, two minutes.

Day	I named what I needed before things derailed	I used a criticism instead	I nourished my Free Child (what?)
Monday	☐	☐	
Tuesday	☐	☐	
Wednesday	☐	☐	
Thursday	☐	☐	
Friday	☐	☐	
Saturday	☐	☐	
Sunday	☐	☐	

One question per evening — just the one for that day:

Monday: *Tonight, which role did I spend the most time in — **Victim, Persecutor, or Rescuer?***

Tuesday: *What did I want to say — and didn't?*

Wednesday: *What need was activated tonight — and how did I choose to meet it?*

Thursday: *What would have happened if I'd said what I needed, directly?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change in my availability for the other person?*

Saturday: *What belief about the other person did this week come to confirm — and is it really true?*

Sunday: *If I replaced the criticism with the real need — what sentence would that give me?*

The next scene has no open criticism. Just a phone call that didn't go well — and two very different ways of being there for someone who's hurting.

Scene 3 — The Call With Her Mother

"Fix Me"

The Scene

Living room, evening. She hangs up, puts her phone on the table. Her face says the call didn't go well.

Her: "My mother, unbelievable. She made another comment about how I'm raising the kids. In front of them too."

Him: "What did you say to her?"

Her: "Nothing. I didn't want it to escalate."

Him: "Next time, you could calmly tell her it's not her place. You don't have to put up with that."

Her: "I know. But it's not that simple with her."

Him: "I understand, but if you don't set a boundary now, it's going to keep happening."

Silence. She looks away.

Her: "Just forget it."

She gets up, goes to the kitchen. He stays on the couch, perplexed — he tried to help.

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one who hung up · the one who advises · both depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you recognize yourself in this scene, you probably know both sides.

You know what it's like to hang up with something heavy in your chest — and to just want someone to be there. Not to explain. Not to structure. Just to stay, and say with their eyes or their words: *I see that this is hard, and you're not alone with it.*

And you might know the other side too: seeing someone you love suffer, and not knowing what to do with your hands. The discomfort of helplessness. The sincere desire to help — which arrives in the form of solutions, because it's the only tool at hand.

Both are legitimate. Both are human.

What this booklet will offer you is a look at what's really happening in the space between these two needs — when one is seeking to be heard, and the other is seeking to be useful. Not to identify a guilty party. To see the mechanics — and find how to get out together.

What's Really Happening

On the surface, it's a conversation about her mother. What's really happening has nothing to do with what should or shouldn't be said next time.

She's just been through something painful. A comment from her mother — not the first, probably not the last — that touches a precise spot: the way she raises her children, meaning something essential to who she is. She hangs up carrying this pain. She talks about it. Not to find a solution — to not be alone with it.

What she's looking for when she puts her phone down and says "*my mother, unbelievable*" isn't an action plan. It's someone who says: *I see that you're hurting. It makes sense to hurt. I'm here.*

He hears something different. He hears a problem — and problems get solved. He activates. He suggests. He structures. He does what he does best when someone he loves is suffering: he looks for how to fix it.

The problem is that what she's bringing him isn't broken. It's painful. And pain doesn't get fixed — it gets traversed, accompanied.

When he says "*you could calmly tell her it's not her place,*" he's convinced he's helping. She hears: you didn't handle that well. When he says "*if you don't set a boundary now, it's going to keep happening,*" he thinks he's right — he probably is. She hears: you're responsible for what your mother does to you.

She says "*just forget it*" and leaves the room. He stays perplexed, sincerely. He tried.

That's the game. Nobody is wrong. Nobody wins.

The Game Being Played — Without Anyone Having Decided It

In psychology, this type of scene has a precise name: the **"Yes But"** game. It's one of the most common patterns in couples — and one of the most misunderstood, precisely because it looks like a request for help.

The structure is always the same. Someone presents a problem. The other suggests a solution. The first responds: *"Yes, but..."* — and explains why it can't work. The other suggests something else. *"Yes, but..."* The sequence repeats until exhaustion — and ends with a silence, a sigh, or a *"just forget it."*

What confuses the one who suggests is the conviction of having correctly heard a request for help. They're right about the form. They're wrong about the substance.

The apparent request is: *"help me find a solution."* The real request — the one operating beneath the surface — sounds more like: *"confirm to me that the situation is truly hard, and that I'm not alone with what I'm feeling."*

The solutions proposed can't be accepted — not because they're bad, but because they would answer the wrong question. Accepting a solution would close something that isn't ready to be closed. It's not bad faith. It's mechanical.

The Victim Who Awakens the Rescuer

There's something important to see here — before the words even arrive.

When she hangs up with that face, when she says *"my mother, unbelievable"* — something activates in him automatically. Not a decision. A reflex. The other person's suffering — even involuntary, even legitimate — awakens the Rescuer. And the Rescuer arrives with solutions, because that's his way of loving.

This reflex isn't a flaw. It's often what makes him attentive, present, reliable. But it has a blind spot: it responds to visible distress without verifying what the other person truly

needs. It assumes that suffering calls for help — and that helping means suggesting.

The more she expresses her pain, the more his Rescuer activates. The more his Rescuer activates, the more she feels misunderstood. The more she feels misunderstood, the more the pain closes off — or explodes. And the loop turns.

The Rescuer believes he's serving the other person. He's first serving his own need not to feel helpless in the face of the suffering of someone he loves. It's not a reproach — it's a mechanism. And seeing it is already beginning to step out of it.

The Karpman Drama Triangle

There are three roles in this game. The **Victim** — the one who suffers, who shares, who seeks to be heard. The **Rescuer** — the one who suggests, who structures, who wants to fix. And the **Persecutor** — the one who, without meaning to, ends up hurting or being hurt.

She arrives as **Victim** — in the technical sense: she's enduring something she didn't choose, and she's talking about it. He immediately enters as **Rescuer** — it's his natural movement in the face of the other's suffering.

The twist comes when his solutions are rejected. He shifts to **Victim** — he tried, he's not understood, what's the point. And she, who was just trying to be heard, finds herself having to manage his perplexity — on top of the pain from the call. She becomes, despite herself, the **Persecutor** of someone who wanted to help.

Victim who shares → awakens → **Rescuer** who suggests → rejection → **Rescuer** becomes **Victim** → the one who was suffering becomes **Persecutor** → silence

Both leave the scene with something unpleasant. Her: alone with her pain, and also guilty for having hurt him. Him: misunderstood in his efforts, with the diffuse feeling of having missed something without knowing what.

What Each Person Gets from It — the Hard Part

This system persists because it confirms something for each person — and because it protects each person from something.

For her: "*when I talk to him about what truly hurts me, I end up managing his reaction.*" This conviction makes future confidences less likely — she'll learn not to talk about it, to handle things alone, to only show what won't trigger advice. Distance settles quietly, without anyone having decided it.

There's something deeper too. As long as the problem with her mother is unsolvable — as long as no solution works — she doesn't have to change anything in that relationship. She doesn't have to set a boundary that frightens her. She doesn't have to face the fact that this relationship is perhaps structurally painful. The game allows her to stay in the suffering — which is real — without having to confront what it asks of her. It's uncomfortable, but it's known.

For him: "*when she suffers, I don't know what to do.*" This helplessness is uncomfortable — and the reflex to suggest solutions is precisely a way of not staying in that discomfort. If I have a plan, I'm not helpless. The problem is that the plan misses the need. And missing the need confirms the helplessness — and therefore reinforces the reflex next time.

Every rejected solution confirms for him that he's trying — that he's present, that he's making efforts. The game allows him to avoid the discomfort of simply being there, doing nothing, not being useful. That helplessness is harder to hold than the accumulation of solutions that don't work.

Both are trapped in something they built together, without seeing it.

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

Here too, the two protagonists are not in the same position — and they don't have the same needs. Two separate readings, therefore.

And in both cases, the same rule: a need belongs to me. It doesn't depend on what the other person does or doesn't do. I am responsible for finding how to meet it — not for waiting for the other person to guess.

If you're the one who hung up

What you express through the "just forget it" isn't rejection. It's information about what you needed — and what you didn't find.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Presence	I need someone to be there with me in what I'm experiencing — without trying to get me out of it
Validation	I need what I feel to be recognized as legitimate — not explained, not minimized
Being heard	I need to be heard before being advised — or instead
Gentleness	I need a soft space to put down what's difficult
Safety	I need to know I can speak without it becoming a debate or a lesson
Autonomy	I need to be trusted to know what I want to do with this situation

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need presence. What I choose to do is say it before starting — 'I need to talk to you about something, but right now I mostly need you to listen, no advice for now.'"

"I need validation. What I choose to do is ask explicitly for what I'd like: 'just tell me it was hard.'"

"I need safety. What I choose to do is name what closes me off — 'when advice comes quickly, I feel less safe continuing to talk.'"

If you're the one who suggested solutions

What you were doing by suggesting wasn't indifference to her pain. It was, in your way, a form of love. But what you were looking for, you, in that exchange, also deserves to be looked at.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Usefulness	I need to feel that I'm contributing — that my presence changes something
Connection	I need this difficult moment to bring us closer rather than separate us
Competence	I need to feel that I know how to do something in the face of what the other person is experiencing
Reciprocity	I need my efforts to be seen — even when they miss the mark
Clarity	I need to know what's expected of me — so I'm not navigating blind

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need clarity. What I choose to do is ask before suggesting: 'do you want us to figure out what to do, or do you mostly need me to listen?'"

"I need connection. What I choose to do is stay there without speaking — just be present, and let that be enough."

"I need usefulness. What I choose to do is remind myself that truly listening is also a form of help — maybe the most useful one here."

The Sentence That Changes Everything

There is one short sentence — a question — that can defuse this scene before it starts. It requires no theoretical work. It just needs to be asked.

"Do you want us to figure out what to do, or do you mostly need me to listen?"

This question does several things at once. It tells the other person: I heard that something is difficult. It leaves them the choice — no presupposition about what they need. And it saves the listener from navigating blind, from suggesting solutions that will miss, from ending up perplexed on the couch.

It's not magic. But it short-circuits the game before it starts.

The Alert Not to Miss

The exit from this game isn't to stop suggesting solutions — or to force yourself to stay silent.

Restraining yourself in silence is another form of the same discomfort. She'll sense it. And constrained silence isn't presence — it's absence with a clear conscience.

The real question for him isn't *"how do I help her handle her mother?"* It's *"what's happening in me when she's suffering and I can't do anything?"* And more precisely: *"are my solutions truly serving her need — or are they first serving my need not to feel helpless?"*

The real question for her isn't *"how do I make him understand that he's not listening to me?"* It's *"what's stopping me from directly saying what I need — not a solution, just to be heard?"*

The Exits

Exit 1 — Ask before responding (solo — the listener)

The next time the other person shares something difficult, before suggesting anything — one question:

"Do you want us to figure out what to do, or do you mostly need me to listen?"

Just that. No interpretation, no assumption. The answer says everything needed to know how to be useful in that moment.

If the answer is *"I need you to listen"* — stay. Suggest nothing. Let the silence do its work. And if the discomfort of helplessness rises, note it internally without responding to it.

Exit 2 — Say what you need before starting (solo — the one speaking)

Before beginning a difficult conversation, a short sentence saying what you need — without waiting for the other person to guess:

"I need to talk to you about something, but right now I mostly need you to listen — no advice for now."

Or, even shorter: *"I just need you to be there."*

This sentence might seem unnecessary — why should I have to ask to be listened to? But it short-circuits the loop before it starts. And it gives the other person what they also need: knowing how to be present.

Exit 3 — Reflect before responding (solo — the listener)

When the other person shares something painful, the solution reflex comes quickly — before you've even truly heard.

A simple practice: before responding, let a silence pass. Not an awkward silence — a silence that says I'm taking time to truly receive what you just said. Then, instead of suggesting, reflect. Name what you heard beneath the words.

"That sounds like it was really hard."

"A comment like that, in front of the kids too — that's hurtful."

"You didn't need that tonight."

"I understand that you didn't want it to escalate."

These sentences solve nothing. They do something more useful: they tell the other person that they're not alone with what they feel. And often, that's all they needed.

Exit 4 — Name the game together (together)

A conversation to have outside the moment of tension — not the night of the call, not in the still-fresh discomfort. A few days later, calmly, 20 minutes.

Each person completes these sentences separately, in writing:

"When I share something painful, what I need first is..."

"When the other person suffers and I can't do anything, what happens in me is..."

"What I find hard to say in these moments is..."

Then you share — each person reads, the other listens without interrupting, without defending. The goal isn't to convince each other. It's to hear what the other person is truly experiencing beneath the surface.

Then, one question to explore together:

"Can we give ourselves a signal — a word, a short phrase — that says 'right now I need to be heard, not advised'? Something we both recognize, and that avoids having to explain this in the moment of pain."

Not a secret code. A shortcut. That can be tested, adjusted, abandoned if it doesn't work.

Feeding Your Free Child — Reminder

There is something operating in the background of this scene — and in all the ones that follow.

When he can't stay in discomfort without acting, it's often a sign that something isn't nourished elsewhere. That the only way he knows to be useful — and therefore to have value — goes through solutions, plans, actions. And when that doesn't work, he's left empty.

When she can't directly say what she needs — when she prefers to close off rather than ask — it's often a sign that something older is activated. Something telling her that her needs are too much, or that they won't be heard anyway.

The Free Child is that part of you that plays, that feels, that expresses itself without calculation. The part that existed before you learned to be useful, or not to ask for too much. It hasn't disappeared. It's just waiting for a little space.

The question to ask yourself tonight:

What did I do today — even five minutes — just for myself? Not to be useful. Not to manage. Just for myself.

Free Child Tracker — 7 days

Every evening, one minute.

Day	What I did for my Free Child	How I felt afterward	Did it change something in my availability for the other person?
Monday			yes · a little · no
Tuesday			yes · a little · no
Wednesday			yes · a little · no
Thursday			yes · a little · no
Friday			yes · a little · no
Saturday			yes · a little · no
Sunday			yes · a little · no

The end-of-week question:

On the days when I nourished my Free Child — did I have more or less urge to solve, to control, to close off? Is there a connection?

Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, two minutes.

Day	I said what I needed before speaking	I asked what the other needed before suggesting	I reflected what the other was feeling	I nourished my Free Child (what?)
Monday	☐	☐	☐	
Tuesday	☐	☐	☐	
Wednesday	☐	☐	☐	
Thursday	☐	☐	☐	
Friday	☐	☐	☐	
Saturday	☐	☐	☐	
Sunday	☐	☐	☐	

One question per evening — just the one for that day:

Monday: *Tonight, which role did I spend the most time in — **Victim, Rescuer, or Persecutor**?*

Tuesday: *When I felt like suggesting a solution — what was I trying to do with my own discomfort?*

Wednesday: *When I shared something difficult, did I say what I needed — or did I let the other person guess?*

Thursday: *What's stopping me from directly saying "I need to be heard, not advised"?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change in my availability for the other person?*

Saturday: *What belief about the other person did this week come to confirm — and is it really true?*

Sunday: *If I replaced the "just forget it" with what I truly needed — what sentence would that give me?*

The next scene takes place in a kitchen, on an ordinary evening. There's a phone, a bank statement, and a bag left on the table. And a question nobody has yet clearly asked.

Scene 4 — Finances

"The Grand Ledger"

The Scene

Kitchen, a weekday evening. He's checking the bank account on his phone. She comes in with a bag.

Him: "Did you go shopping again?"

Her: "I needed a few things."

Him: "We said we'd be careful this month. We're already in the red."

Her: "It wasn't much. And besides, it's my money too."

Him: "I'm not saying it's not your money. I'm saying we have a shared budget and you're not taking it into account."

Her: "Are you monitoring everything I do now?"

He puts down his phone. Silence.

Him: "Just forget it."

She puts down the bag, leaves the room. The bag stays on the table.

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one who monitors · the one who spends · both depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you recognize yourself in this scene, you probably know both sides.

You know what it's like to look at a statement and feel something tighten. Not malice — a real, diffuse anxiety, hard to articulate without it coming out as a criticism. The feeling that the framework you'd set isn't holding. That decisions aren't really being made together. And not knowing how to say it without seeming like you're monitoring.

And you might know the other side too: coming home with something — a purchase, a gesture for yourself — and sensing the gaze before you've even put the bag down. The feeling of having to justify yourself for something that didn't seem so serious. And the question rising, not always articulated: *am I free in this relationship?*

Both are real. Both are legitimate. And they rarely meet — because each is responding to what they hear, not to what the other is really saying.

What this booklet will offer you is a look at what's really happening beneath the surface — not to identify who's wrong, but because it's the only place from which something can change.

What's Really Happening

On the surface, it's an argument about an overspent budget. What's really happening has almost nothing to do with the amount on the statement.

Money in a couple is never just money. It's the terrain on which much more loaded questions play out: who decides, who controls, who trusts, who is free, who is responsible. What each person does with money — spending, holding back, monitoring, ignoring — says something about what they need and what they fear. Not consciously. But really.

There's also, often, a question the two of them have never truly settled — not because they've avoided it, but because it's never been clearly posed.

How much is money **ours**?

The shift from **my** money to **our** money is not automatic. It requires a decision — conscious, explicit, chosen together — about what goes into the common pool, what stays separate, and what that says about how you bind yourselves. Some couples merge everything from the start, without discussing it. Others maintain separate zones, without having truly decided that either. And many live in a fuzzy in-between — a shared account for expenses, personal accounts for the rest — without ever having named what that organization says about their relationship.

"It's my money too" — that sentence in the scene isn't just a claim to autonomy. It's a sign that this question hasn't yet been resolved. Not between the numbers. Between them.

And as long as it hasn't been, the budget argument goes in circles — because it's looking for a financial answer to a question that is first relational.

Here, he opens the account and sees an overspend. What he feels isn't just financial anxiety — it's something more diffuse: the sense that decisions aren't being made together, that the agreement isn't being respected, that the shared framework isn't holding. It's not yet a criticism — it's an anxiety looking for an outlet. And it comes out through monitoring.

She comes home with a bag. She doesn't feel she's done something serious — or if she does, she doesn't want to admit it. When he points out the overspend, she hears something other than what he's saying. She hears: **you're not reliable. I have to monitor you. You're not free.** And to that sentence, she responds — not to the budget.

"Are you monitoring everything I do?" isn't a question about bank statements. It's a question about trust, autonomy, the place she has in this relationship.

Nobody is talking about what they're really talking about. And that's why it doesn't get resolved.

The Ego States Present:

	Him	Her
Normative Parent	"We said we'd be careful" — he enforces the rule, he reframes	—
Nurturing Parent	Variant: he manages, he anticipates, he protects the household — in his way	—
Adult	Absent — the real anxiety is never named	Absent — the need for autonomy is never named
Wounded Child	Beneath the monitoring: a fear — that things will spiral, that the other isn't reliable, that the framework will collapse	Beneath the spending: something looking to fill itself
Rebellious Child	—	"It's my money too" — she counter-attacks, she refuses the guardianship
Adapted Submissive Child	"Just forget it" — he withdraws, exhausted	Variant: she minimizes, she justifies

What's striking: the two are operating from states that cannot meet. His Normative Parent is addressing an Adult that isn't there. Her Rebellious Child is responding to a Parent she doesn't want to acknowledge. The Adult — the one who could talk about budget, needs, shared decisions — is absent on both sides.

The Victim Who Awakens the Controller

There's a reflex here that mirrors what we saw in the previous scene — but reversed.

When he perceives a budget overrun, something activates in him automatically. Not a decision. A protection reflex. The perceived threat — financial, but also relational — awakens the Normative Parent in control mode. He checks, he reframes, he restates the rules.

This reflex isn't arbitrary. It often comes from a precise place: fear of instability, a relationship with money built early, a conviction that if nobody watches everything falls apart. It's not him monitoring **her** — it's him monitoring the system, because the system

represents something vital.

But she doesn't see the system. She sees the gaze on her. And that gaze activates her *Rebellious Child* — the one who refuses the guardianship, who reclaims her place, who says *I'm not a child being monitored*.

Both are reacting to something real. And neither is reacting to what the other is truly saying.

The Karpman Drama Triangle — the Drama in Three Acts

What makes this triangle particular is that it starts before the words even arrive. The game is already underway when she pushes the door open.

Act 1 — before she comes home. He checks the account. He sees the overspend. Something tightens. He hasn't said anything yet — but he's already in **Victim** mode: alone with an anxiety he carries, a framework he monitors, a decision that was made without him. The other person isn't there yet, and the game has already started.

Act 2 — she comes home. She puts down the bag. He says: "did you go shopping again?" He shifts to **Persecutor** — not by intention, but by effect. The question isn't neutral. It points. It evaluates. It places the other in a position of having to justify themselves.

She enters as **Victim** — surprised, or perhaps not entirely. She knew. And something in her had prepared for this.

Act 3 — the twist. "Are you monitoring everything I do?" She shifts to **Persecutor**. It's no longer a response to the budget — it's a counter-attack on the terrain of control and freedom. He becomes **Victim** again: he was just trying to hold to an agreement, and he finds himself accused of monitoring.

"Just forget it." He withdraws. The game stops — without a winner, without resolution. The bag stays on the table. And each leaves with the confirmation of what they feared.

Victim alone with the statement → **Persecutor** on her arrival → her as **Victim** → she shifts to **Persecutor** → him as **Victim** → withdrawal → mutual confirmation of what they already feared

The Hidden Benefit of the Drama

This triangle persists because it protects something — in each person, differently.

For him: monitoring is a way of not being overwhelmed by an anxiety he doesn't always know how to name. If I have the framework in hand, I'm not helpless. It's not control for control's sake — it's a response to something older, often, around instability or loss. The problem is that this response costs the other person what she needs most: feeling free.

For her: spending without saying anything preserves a zone that belongs to her. A decision made alone, for herself, without negotiation. It's not irresponsibility — it's often a need for autonomy that hasn't yet found another path. The problem is that this path costs the other person what he needs most: feeling like they're on the same team.

Both protect something legitimate. And both do so in a way that hurts exactly where the other person is most vulnerable. It's not malice — it's what happens when two real needs have never been spoken aloud.

Why She Spends — Lines of Inquiry

Before talking about budget, there's a more useful question than "*how much did you spend?*"

What was this spending trying to do?

Not to excuse. Not to normalize. But because understanding what's really happening beneath the spending completely changes the nature of the conversation — and opens the possibility of a real response instead of a numbers conflict.

A few lines of inquiry — several can coexist, and none is universal:

Spending as self-care. After a hard week, a purchase — even small — can be the only way to give yourself something. Not luxury: gentleness. A concrete gesture that says I matter too. If the rest of life is organized around other people's needs, this spending might be the only zone where she chooses for herself.

Spending as a territory of autonomy. In a relationship where financial decisions are asymmetric — one who earns more, one who monitors more, one who decides more — spending without asking can be a silent way of reclaiming a place. I'm not asking your permission. It's not rational. It's identity-based.

Spending as emotional regulation. Shopping, like other compulsive behaviors, can be a response to a difficult inner state — anxiety, boredom, sadness, a feeling of emptiness. The purchase produces a quick stimulation, a mini-satisfaction. The problem isn't the spending — it's what it comes to cover, which remains whole afterward.

Spending as a test. Sometimes, unconsciously, exceeding an agreement is a way of testing the other person's reaction. Will he notice? Will he react? Is he paying attention to what's happening for me? It's not a strategy — it's a need for connection expressing itself the wrong way.

These lines of inquiry aren't excuses. They're entry points toward a different

conversation. The one that begins with "*what's been going on for you this month?*" rather than "*you went shopping again.*"

And for him too, a symmetrical question deserves to be asked: *why is controlling money so important to me?* What does the budget overrun really activate — financial anxiety, or something older around instability, trust, the feeling of being overwhelmed?

There's often something paradoxical in this position. What irritates about the other — the lightness, the impulse, the ability to spend without thinking — is sometimes exactly what one would need oneself. But an overly present inner Parent makes it inaccessible. *I have to be reasonable. I have to hold things together. This isn't the time.* And seeing the other grant themselves what you deny yourself creates an irritation that resembles anger — but often hides something softer: sadness, or fear.

What each person does with money also says something deeper — about what they value, what they consider legitimate, what they allow themselves. Two people can have identical incomes and radically different relationships to money — because those relationships aren't built on numbers. They're built on stories. What you saw in your family of origin. What you learned to associate with spending — pleasure, guilt, freedom, danger. What money represented when you were a child — security, scarcity, power, lightness.

This isn't incompatibility. It's a difference in values that hasn't yet been named. And an unnamed difference always ends up expressing itself — as criticism, resistance, or silence.

The Alert Not to Miss

The exit from this game isn't to better stick to the budget — or to monitor less.

Sticking to the budget without changing the dynamic produces an underground tension that explodes elsewhere. And monitoring less without addressing the real anxiety creates an anxiety that looks for another outlet.

The real question for him isn't *"how do I get her to respect the budget?"* It's *"what does the overrun really activate in me — and where does that come from?"*

The real question for her isn't *"how do I make him understand it's my money too?"* It's *"what am I looking for when I spend without saying anything — and could that thing be asked for differently?"*

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

Before going further, one important point.

In this scene, the two protagonists are not in the same position — and they don't have the same needs. Mixing them means missing something essential.

What follows offers two separate readings. Not to identify a guilty party and a victim. To allow each person to honestly recognize what's activated in them — and find their own exit.

And in both cases, the same rule applies: a need belongs to me. It doesn't depend on what the other person does or doesn't do. I am responsible for finding how to meet it — not for waiting for the other person to guess.

If you're the one who monitors

What you express through the statement isn't really control. It's information about

what's missing — and about what you don't allow yourself.

There's often something paradoxical in this position. What irritates about the other — the lightness, the impulse, the ability to spend without thinking — is sometimes exactly what you would need yourself. But an overly present inner Parent makes it inaccessible. *I have to be reasonable. I have to hold things together. This isn't the time.* And seeing the other grant themselves what you deny yourself creates an irritation that resembles anger — but often hides something softer: sadness, or fear.

The fear, often, of collapse. Of not being able to manage. Someone in survival mode can't project forward — lightness becomes a luxury that seems dangerous. And from that place, monitoring is a clumsy way of trying to build something — a shared framework, a common momentum, a *we're in this together*.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Lightness	I need to allow myself lightness — not wait for the financial situation to permit i
Inner security	I need to find a feeling of stability within myself — not just in the numbers
Clarity	I need the framework we set to be truly chosen together — not carried alone
Sharing	I need to feel we're building something together — not each on their own side

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need ___. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is ___."

A few examples:

"I need lightness. What I choose to do is allow myself something this week — even small — without justifying it. And observe what that changes in my availability for the other person."

"I need sharing. What I choose to do is propose a conversation about what we want to build together — not about what went wrong."

"I need clarity. What I choose to do is name my anxiety directly — not as a criticism, but as something that belongs to me and that I'd like to face together."

If you're the one who spends

What you express through the purchase isn't irresponsibility. It's information about what you need — and about what's missing when every decision becomes negotiating territory.

The spending says something that words don't say yet. Sometimes it's self-care — the only gesture this week that was for you. Sometimes it's claimed autonomy — a decision made alone, without having to ask permission. Sometimes it's regulation — something difficult to get through, and the purchase that brings a quick mini-satisfaction. And sometimes, without deciding it, it's a way of testing: *is he paying attention to what's happening for me?*

It's not a strategy. It's a need that hasn't yet found its direct path.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Freedom	I need a zone that belongs to me — choices I make for myself, without accounting for them
Self-care	I need to give myself something sometimes — gentleness, pleasure, lightness
Expression	I need to exist in this relationship as someone who has their own impulses — not just their responsibilities
Vitality	I need to feel that our shared life has space for impulse, spontaneity, the living

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need freedom. What I choose to do is propose that we think together about a personal

allowance — money each of us has freely, without justification."

"I need self-care. What I choose to do is find other ways to do myself good that don't go only through spending — and name what I need rather than looking for it alone."

"I need vitality. What I choose to do is propose something light this week — nothing big, just something that steps outside the management."

These two lists don't oppose each other. They never meet in the scene — because the scene doesn't give them space. But they speak, at bottom, of the same thing: two people trying to live, each in their own way, in a space that's meant to be shared.

Feeding Your Free Child

There is something operating in the background of this scene — and worth naming.

The one who monitors has often locked away their own lightness for a long time. The **Normative Parent** has taken too much space — *I have to hold things together; I have to manage, this isn't the time*. And the **Free Child**, that part that plays, that treats itself, that sometimes spends for no valid reason, has learned to be quiet. The result: reduced emotional availability, underlying irritability, and a quiet jealousy toward the one who seems able to do what you forbid yourself.

The one who spends is trying to nourish their **Free Child** — but through a path that triggers conflict rather than creating space. Spending is an attempt at lightness. Not always the most direct one.

Both need the same thing — to allow themselves lightness, each in their own way, without it going through money or through the other person.

The question to ask yourself tonight:

What did I do today — even five minutes — just for myself? Not to manage. Not to be responsible. Just for the pleasure of existing.

And an additional question, specific to this scene:

What do I forbid myself — and why? Does this prohibition truly protect me, or does it impoverish me?

The Exits

Level 1 — Notice what money represents (solo — both partners)

Before the next financial conversation, one internal question:

When I think about money in this relationship, what do I feel — and where does it come from?

For the one who monitors: is it concrete anxiety, or something older around instability, loss, the feeling of not being in control?

For the one who spends: is it a real need, a gesture of self-care, a territory of autonomy — or something looking to fill something else?

No need to talk about it yet. Just name it, internally.

Level 2 — Separate money from power (solo — both partners)

A simple practice: the next time the financial question comes up, note mentally whether the conversation is about the numbers — or about something else. The budget, autonomy, trust, freedom, control.

If it's something else, the conversation about numbers will solve nothing. There's a different conversation to have — and it starts by naming what's really at stake.

Level 3 — Create space to talk about money differently (together)

A conversation about money can't happen in the moment the statement has just been checked. Not in the tension of the criticism, not in the defense that follows. It needs another space — chosen, calm, with a shared intention.

Not a meeting. Not an audit. More like a moment decided together, outside any urgency, with one question as the entry point:

"Can we talk about what money means to each of us — not about what was spent, but about what we want to build?"

That shift changes everything. We're no longer talking about numbers — we're talking about values, needs, what we imagine for the future. And from that place, things become possible that weren't possible in the kitchen, the bag still on the table.

A few questions to structure this exchange:

"What does money represent for you in our relationship — concretely and symbolically?"

"What have we never truly decided together — and that would deserve to be decided?"

"What do you need to feel free — and what do I need to feel secure? Can we find something that serves both?"

"Can we set aside an envelope for each of us — money each person has freely, without having to justify it — and a shared envelope for joint decisions?"

This isn't a win-lose negotiation. It's two people looking together for a system that respects both what one needs to feel grounded — and what the other needs to feel alive.

Level 4 — Name the game together (together)

A few days after the scene, calmly:

"I realize that when we talk about money, we're rarely just talking about money. I tend to monitor when I feel anxious — you tend to spend when you need space. Does that resonate?"

Not an accusation. A shared observation — that opens the possibility of talking about what's really happening.

Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, 2 minutes.

Day	I named a real need behind a money question	I monitored or spent without saying anything	I proposed something rather than accusing	I nourished my Free Child (what?)
Monday	☐	☐	☐	
Tuesday	☐	☐	☐	
Wednesday	☐	☐	☐	
Thursday	☐	☐	☐	
Friday	☐	☐	☐	
Saturday	☐	☐	☐	
Sunday	☐	☐	☐	

The evening question:

Monday: *Today, what did money represent in my interactions — beyond the numbers?*

Tuesday: *When I spent or monitored, what was I truly looking for?*

Wednesday: *At what moment did I use money to say something I didn't say in words?*

Thursday: *What would I have needed to ask for — or offer — instead?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change in my relationship to money?*

Saturday: *What belief about the other person did this scene come to confirm this week?*

Sunday: *If money were no longer a terrain of power between us — what would that conversation look like?*

Duo Version — Exchange in 2 Parts

To do outside any recent overspend — calmly, 20 minutes.

Part 1 — What Money Represents (10 minutes)

Each person completes these sentences separately, in writing:

"In our relationship, money represents for me..." "What I need to feel free / financially secure is..." "What I've never allowed myself — and would like to be able to give myself — is..."

Then you share — each person reads, the other listens without interrupting. The goal isn't to convince each other. It's to hear what money truly represents for the other person — beyond the numbers.

Part 2 — A Framework That Respects Both (10 minutes)

One question to explore together:

"How do we build something that gives you security and gives me freedom — at the same time?"

Not an imposed rule. A proposal built together — that can be adjusted, tested, revised.

The next scene enters even more delicate terrain — that of parenting. Two parents, a child who resists, and two ways of loving that don't speak to each other.

Scene 5 — Homework

"The Bad Parent"

The Scene

Living room, 6:30 pm. The child is at the table with homework. She's beside him, tense. He comes in, puts his things down.

Her: "He refused to do his homework again. I've been struggling with him for an hour."

Him: "Come on, let's go." (to the child, firm tone) "Put the tablet down and get to work now."

The child complies, sulking. She waits until the child is out of earshot.

Her: "You walk in and take over like that — in front of him."

Him: "He wasn't doing anything. You were negotiating for an hour."

Her: "I'm not negotiating. I'm trying to understand what's blocking him."

Him: "What's blocking him is there's no clear limit. If you set the limit, he respects it."

Her: "And what do you think cold authority builds?"

Silence. The child comes back to get his notebook. They go quiet. Facade smiles.

Later, once the child is asleep:

Him: "I just wanted to help."

Her: "That's not how you help me."

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one who sets the limit · the one who tries to understand
· both depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you recognize yourself in this scene, you probably know what it feels like to hold a course — and see it bypassed in thirty seconds.

You know what it's like to have thought through your approach. Not improvising — choosing. Choosing not to shout, to look for what's blocking, to try to understand the child rather than force them. And to see someone arrive, without context, without the path traveled, and resolve the situation the old way — with the firmness you had specifically decided to set aside. And it works. That's the hardest part to swallow.

And you might know the other side too: coming home into a tense situation, seeing someone you love exhausted, a child who resists, and feeling that reflex rise — I can fix this. Quickly. Simply. With what you know. Not out of contempt for what the other person was doing — out of genuine desire for it to stop. For everyone. Including yourself.

Both positions are honest. They're also both incomplete.

What this booklet will offer you is to look not at who has the better method — that question has no answer in the moment of tension — but at what each person was really activating in this scene, beyond the parenting. Because that's where something can change.

What's Really Happening

On the surface, it's a disagreement about how to get homework done. What's really happening is much more charged — and much older.

When two parents clash about parenting, they're rarely debating pedagogy. They're debating what a good parent is. And behind that question is another, deeper one that nobody articulates: *am I a good parent?* And behind that still:

do I have worth in this role that matters more than anything?

That's why these arguments hurt so much. It's not the disagreement about homework that's painful. It's the implicit implication — your way of doing things is wrong — that touches something identity-based. And something, often, very old.

What Comes from Further Back

Each person arrives in parenthood with a history. With internalized images of what a parent is — how they set limits, how they console, how they demand, how they're present. These images come from childhood. They weren't chosen. They're there, active, often without our knowing.

He may have grown up in an environment where clear rules were synonymous with security. Where authority was love — not coldness. When he sets the limit, he's not thinking "*I'm taking power.*" He's thinking "*I'm protecting.*"

She may have grown up in an environment where authority was arbitrary, or absent, or hurtful. Where understanding what was happening for the child was what was missing. When she tries to understand what's blocking, she's not thinking "*I'm negotiating.*" She's thinking "*I'm seeing.*"

Neither is wrong. They're reproducing — often without knowing it — what they received, or what they would have liked to receive. And when their two histories collide on the terrain of a child's homework, much more than homework is at stake.

The Ego States Present:

	Him	Her
Normative Parent	"Put the tablet down now" — he sets the limit, he structures	"What does cold authority build?" — she reframes his method
Nurturing Parent	—	"I'm trying to understand what's blocking him" — she tries to see the child
Adult	Absent — the method is never discussed together, calmly	Absent — the need for coherence is never named
Wounded Child	Beneath the firmness: something was activated when he came home	Beneath the resistance: <i>"that's not how you help me"</i> — she feels discredited
Adapted Submissive Child	"I just wanted to help" — he backs down, tries to repair	—

What's striking: both are operating from the Parent — him from the Normative, her from the Nurturing. Two forms of parental love. Two ways of being a good parent. Incompatible in the moment, not at heart.

The Adult is absent on both sides. It can't be there because the scene is no longer about homework. It's about who is right to love the child the way they love them.

The Life Positions Present

In Transactional Analysis, a *life position* is the deep conviction we carry about ourselves and the other — built early, rarely conscious, always active in moments of tension.

He operates from something that resembles *"I'm OK — what you're doing isn't."* Not out of contempt — out of conviction that his way is right. It's a position of implicit superiority that shows in the unsolicited intervention, in *"if you set the limit, he respects it."*

She slides toward something that resembles *"I'm doing my best — and you come to show me it's not enough."* A position that combines the legitimacy of her approach and

the hurt of being discredited in front of the child.

These positions aren't fixed. They move in the scene — he slides into "*I'm not OK*" when he says "*I just wanted to help*," she regains the high ground when she challenges his cold authority. But their collision is enough to make the conversation impossible.

The Karpman Drama Triangle — the Drama in Three Acts

This is where the scene reveals its full mechanics. What's particularly striking in this configuration is the speed at which the roles shift.

Act 1 — before he comes home. She's been struggling for an hour. She's exhausted, overwhelmed, alone facing the child's resistance. She's in **Victim** mode — not in the weak sense, but in the technical sense: she's enduring a situation she no longer controls, and carrying it alone.

Act 2 — he comes home and intervenes. He sees the scene. His reflex is immediate — he enters as **Rescuer**. He takes over, sets the limit, gets the result. The child obeys. He's repaired what seemed broken.

But something shifts. By becoming the **Rescuer** of the situation, he implicitly becomes the **Persecutor** of her — he bypassed her authority, in front of the child, without asking. What he experienced as a rescue, she experienced as a humiliation.

Act 3 — the twist. She counter-attacks: "you walk in and take over like that." She shifts to **Persecutor**. He slides into **Victim** — he tried to help, he's being criticized for it. And later, "I just wanted to help" says exactly this position: I am the **victim** of your reaction to my help.

She, who was **Victim** at the start, ends up in the uncomfortable position of the one who hurt someone who meant well. The guilt is there, even if unnamed.

Victim (her) → **Rescuer** (him) → Implicit **Persecutor** (him) → **Victim** (her,

discredited) → **Persecutor** (her attacking) → **Victim** (him, misunderstood) → diffuse guilt on both sides

The Hidden Benefit of the Drama

This triangle persists because it protects something — in each person, differently.

For him: getting a quick result avoids having to enter into what had been happening for an hour. If it works, that's because it was the right way. And being the one who solves says something reassuring about his place in this household — he's useful, he matters.

For her: naming what just happened protects the meaning of what she's building. Letting it go without saying anything would be allowing an entire path to be silently invalidated. The criticism isn't just anger — it's a way of saying *what I do has value, even if you didn't see it*.

Both protect something legitimate. And neither protects what most needs protecting — the space between them, from which a real conversation about parenting could one day take place.

The "Courtroom" Game — Who Is the Better Parent?

What Berne calls "*Courtroom*" isn't a game of cruelty. It's a game of legitimacy — often unconscious, always revealing of what couldn't be said otherwise.

The structure: a decision is made, contradicted, or judged. One takes the position of accuser — "*you were negotiating for an hour*" — and the other the position of defendant — "*I'm not negotiating, I'm trying to understand*." The real issue isn't the decision. It's the verdict: who is right to be the parent they are?

This game has a precise secondary benefit. For him: intervening and getting a quick result confirms his approach works. For her: resisting his intervention and pointing out

its limits confirms she sees what he doesn't see.

Both are looking for the same thing — to be recognized as competent, loving, sufficient. And they're looking for it by opposing each other. It's not rational. It's human.

The Alert Not to Miss

The exit from this game isn't to align on a single method — or to decide who is right between limit-setting and understanding.

Both approaches have value. The problem isn't the method — it's the disunity.

The real question for him: *"what does it activate in me to see this scene when I come home — and why do I intervene before even asking what's happening?"*

The real question for her: *"what am I truly building — and how do I make it visible to the other person, other than in the moment of tension?"*

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

In this scene, the two protagonists aren't experiencing the same thing — and they don't have the same needs. What follows offers two separate readings. Not to designate who's right about the method. To allow each person to recognize what's activated in them — and find their own exit.

The same rule applies in both cases: a need belongs to me. It doesn't depend on what the other person does or doesn't do. I am responsible for finding how to meet it — not for waiting for the other person to guess.

If you're the one whose efforts were bypassed

What you express through the resistance and the criticism isn't stubbornness. It's information about what matters deeply to you — and about what disappears without leaving a trace when the result erases the path.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Meaning	I need what I do to have value — not just a visible result, but a path that counts
Integrity	I need to act in accordance with what I believe is right — even when it's slower, harder
Growth	I need to build something different from what I received — not to reproduce what I decided to move past
Inner peace	I need to feel aligned with my parenting values — not torn between what I believe and what's happening

"I need __. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is __."

A few examples:

"I need meaning. What I choose to do is continue my approach — even without immediate results — and observe what it builds over time, not just tonight."

"I need integrity. What I choose to do is stay with what I believe is right for this child — and find a calm moment to share this path with the other person, not impose it, just make it visible."

"I need growth. What I choose to do is name, for myself first, what I want to transmit — and what I don't want to reproduce. Not as a criticism of the other. As a compass for myself."

If you're the one who intervened

What you did wasn't contempt. It was a reflex — quick, efficient, inherited. But a reflex isn't a choice. And the question worth asking isn't "did it work?" It's "what was activated in me — and what does that say about what I truly need?"

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Inner peace	I need the tension to stop — not to flee, but because conflict exhausts me deeply
Contribution	I need to feel that I'm useful — that my presence has a real effect in this household
Simplicity	I need things to be clear — that rules set are held, that the framework is legible
Self-confidence	I need to feel that my way of doing things has value — even if it's different, even if it's questioned

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need __. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is __."

A few examples:

"I need inner peace. What I choose to do is give myself a moment to decompress when I come home — before entering into what's happening — so I don't intervene from exhaustion."

"I need contribution. What I choose to do is ask the other person how I can help — before

acting. Just that. Two seconds. Before."

"I need self-confidence. What I choose to do is examine what my parenting automatisms carry — what they've given me, what they reproduce — without defending or wholesale rejecting them."

These two lists speak of the same aspiration — being a parent who acts from what they truly believe, not from reflex or fatigue. They don't meet in the scene. But they can meet calmly, when both have decided to speak not of method — but of what they truly want to build together.

Feeding Your Free Child

There is something operating in the background of this scene — worth naming.

Both arrive in this moment from their Parent. Him from the Normative — the rule, the limit, the efficiency. Her from the Nurturing — the understanding, the care, the patience. Two serious forms of love. Two ways of being there for this child that cost a lot — and that leave little room for anything else.

What's rarely seen from the inside: the tension that builds in these moments isn't just the product of the interaction. It's also what we bring to it. When we're very focused on doing things right — on the result, on the method, on what's just — we arrive in the relationship with little breath. And that absence of breath is transmitted. To the child. To the other parent. It nourishes exactly what we wanted to avoid.

Feeding your Free Child isn't a way of being a less good parent. It's a way of taking care of yourself — so you arrive in the relationship differently. Not less demanding. Less tense. And that difference, the child senses before the words even arrive.

It's not about changing the homework scene first. It's about asking what you allowed yourself today — outside your role as parent, outside the couple, outside what you must. A moment that belongs only to you. Not much. But something.

Because taking care of yourself is taking care of the relationship. Not instead of the demand — alongside it. And often, when you allow yourself this breath, the demand settles on its own — without having decided anything else.

The question to ask yourself tonight:

What did I allow myself today — not to be useful, not to do things right — just for myself?

And an additional question, specific to this scene:

Was the tension I experienced tonight only in the situation — or was I already bringing it with me when I walked into the room?

The Exits

Level 1 — Notice your role in the triangle (solo — both partners)

One question, in the moment:

What role am I in right now — Victim, Rescuer, or Persecutor?

If you're **Victim**: what are you waiting for from the other — support, a solution? Can you ask for it directly rather than waiting?

If you're **Rescuer**: were you asked to intervene? Does your intervention serve the other — or does it first serve your need to be useful?

If you're **Persecutor**: what are you truly defending — a parenting method, or your legitimacy as a parent?

Noticing the role doesn't make it disappear immediately. But it creates a space — a slight distance between reflex and reaction — from which something else becomes possible.

Level 2 — Observe from which place you're speaking (solo — both partners)

The next time this scene is triggered, a complementary question:

Am I reacting to the child, or am I reacting to the other parent?

If the primary emotion is frustration toward the child — it's a parenting question. If the primary emotion is frustration toward the other — it's a couple question disguised as a parenting question. Both deserve a response. But not the same one.

Level 3 — Set a handover protocol (together — to build outside tension)

The handover scene is inevitable in any couple with children. What creates the problem is that it's never been discussed. It's improvised, in the moment, under tension.

A conversation to have calmly, without the child:

"When one of us is struggling — how do we hand over without bypassing each other? What does each of us need from the other in that moment?"

Not a rigid rule. A flexible agreement — a signal, a phrase, a gesture that says "I need help" or "I'll take over, you breathe." Something chosen together, not imposed in the urgency.

Level 4 — Name the divergence in approach without making it a verdict (together)

"I realize we've never really talked about our parenting approaches — what we want for them, what matters to each of us, what we received and what we want to reproduce or not. Can we do that — not to decide who's right, but to understand each other?"

This conversation moves disagreements from the terrain of reaction to the terrain of choice. It allows each person to hear where the other is coming from — not as a threat, but as a history.

Level 5 — Name the game together (together)

A few days after the scene, calmly:

"I think we sometimes replay something — not about the homework, but about who is the good parent. I jump in as Rescuer without being asked, and that puts you in an impossible

position. I see that now. Can we talk about it?"

Not an accusation. A shared observation from the Adult — that opens the possibility of talking about what's really happening.

Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, 2 minutes.

Day	What role did I occupy?	I asked before intervening	I nourished my Free Child (what?)
Monday	V · R · P	☐	
Tuesday	V · R · P	☐	
Wednesday	V · R · P	☐	
Thursday	V · R · P	☐	
Friday	V · R · P	☐	
Saturday	V · R · P	☐	
Sunday	V · R · P	☐	

V = Victim · R = Rescuer · P = Persecutor

The evening question:

Monday: *Which role did I spend the most time in today — and what led me there?*

Tuesday: *What was activated in me when I came home tonight — and where did it come from?*

Wednesday: *At what moment did I see the other person's approach as a threat rather than a difference?*

Thursday: *What has my history taught me about what a good parent is — and is it still playing out here?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change in my presence?*

Saturday: *What did I allow myself this week — just for myself?*

Sunday: *If we were truly a team in these moments — what would that look like concretely?*

Duo Version — Exchange in 2 Parts

To do outside any recent episode — calmly, without the child present, 20 minutes.

Part 1 — Our Parenting Histories (10 minutes)

Each person completes these sentences separately, in writing:

"What I received as an upbringing, and want to pass on, is..." "What I didn't receive, and try to give, is..." "What I need from you in the difficult moments with the children is..."

Then you share — each person reads, the other listens without interrupting. The goal isn't to decide on a common method. It's to hear where the other is coming from.

Part 2 — A Handover Agreement (10 minutes)

"How do we support each other in these moments — without bypassing each other?"

Not a rigid protocol. A flexible, revisable agreement that says: we're a team. And when one is exhausted, the other takes over — in a way that respects what the other started.

The last scene is the most silent of all. It takes place in the dark, at 11 pm. And what plays out in it lasted only thirty seconds.

Scene 6 — The Bedroom

"Not Tonight"

Before the Scene — A Few Words About What's Really at Stake

This scene is different from the five before it. Not because it's more serious. Because it's closer.

Household tasks, return times, money, children — these are subjects you can put on the table, debate, negotiate. They have an external form. You can point to something concrete.

Sexuality in a couple doesn't have that form. It touches something that resists words — desire, vulnerability, the need to be wanted. And behind those words, something even more fundamental: *do I matter to you? Do you see me — not as a roommate, not as the parent of our children, not as someone you share a budget with — but as someone you hold on to, specifically, intimately?*

That's why this subject is so hard to approach. Not because it's taboo — even though the modesty is real. Because it exposes something that can't be defended with arguments.

There's also a widespread belief, rarely articulated, that complicates everything: *sexuality is what differentiates us from a friendship. If it disappears, what are we?* This belief transforms every refusal into an existential threat to the bond. And every request into a test of the state of the relationship.

It's not a truth. But it's a very active belief — and it deserves to be named before entering the scene.

One last thing. What most people are looking for when they seek physical intimacy isn't always what they're asking for. Behind sexual desire, there's often something simpler and deeper: warmth. Connection. The certainty of existing for the other in a way that belongs only to the two of you. Sex can be the path to that — or the only path you know to get there. But it's not the only route.

It's from that place that this scene deserves to be read.

The Scene

Bedroom, 11 pm. They're in bed. The lights are off. He moves closer, places a hand on her shoulder.

Him: (low voice) "Are you asleep?"

Her: "Not yet."

A silence. He stays close.

Her: "I'm really tired tonight."

Him: "Yeah." (he turns to his side)

Silence. Both lying with eyes open in the dark.

Her: (after a moment) "Are you angry?"

Him: "No. Sleep well."

She turns over. The silence settles — not peaceful. Each on their own side, each in their own head.

Do You Recognize Yourself?

I experience this scene: never · sometimes · often

In this scene, I'm more like: the one who moves closer · the one who says no · both depending on the moment

Before the Analysis — One Important Thing

If you recognize yourself in this scene, you probably know what it feels like to want something — and not know how to say it.

The silent approach at 11 pm isn't a request. It's an attempt. A gesture that hopes to be understood without having to expose itself further. And that way of not saying — of leaving the other person to guess — puts the other in a difficult position: responding in the heat of the moment, from exhaustion, to a request they didn't have time to receive. Often exhausted. Often already elsewhere in their head.

The refusal that follows isn't always rejection. It's often the response of a body that has no more resource — not for this, not now. But because the request wasn't stated, the refusal can't be nuanced either. It arrives blunt, even when it's gentle. And in the silence that follows, each is left alone with what they didn't say.

What was missing in this scene wasn't desire. It was a conversation — earlier in the evening, in a moment when both were still available. *"I'd love it if we had a moment together tonight."* That sentence opens something. It leaves the other free to respond — not from obligation or rejection, but from what's truly possible for them. Maybe not what was asked for. But maybe something — a hug, a closeness, a moment of warmth that asks for nothing but says we're still us.

Intimacy doesn't come down to sexuality. And it's often when we believe it's all or nothing that we end up with nothing.

What's Really Happening

What happened in this scene lasted only thirty seconds. And yet both will take time to fall asleep.

He didn't ask for something. He moved closer. That gesture — simple, silent, vulnerable — carried something he couldn't have easily articulated. Perhaps: I want you. I want to be close. I need to feel we're still us. Perhaps something even simpler: I

want to touch you.

She said no — gently, without brutality, with real tiredness. She didn't reject him. She refused something she didn't have the energy to give tonight. The nuance is real. But in the darkness, in the silence that followed, this nuance was lost.

"*Are you angry?*" says she sensed something. Not anger — withdrawal. That withdrawal spoke to her more loudly than his words. And his "no, sleep well" — too short, too clean — confirmed what she feared: that he was hurt. That she'd done something wrong by simply being tired.

Nobody said what was really happening. Nobody had the words for it — not at 11 pm, not in the dark, not without risking something.

A Word on Differences — Without Generalizing

There's a reality this scene carries without naming it: desire doesn't work the same way for everyone. And in many couples — not all, but many — there's a gap. One is more often the initiator, the other more often in withdrawal. This isn't about a lack of love. It's not a fatality either.

This gap often comes from things that are both simple and deep. Fatigue accumulates differently. Stress cuts desire differently. The need for connection expresses itself differently — one through the body, the other through words, shared time, daily tenderness. What one reads as a signal of intimacy — *he moves closer, he wants me* — the other sometimes reads as pressure — *another request I don't have the energy to honor*.

These differences aren't flaws. They're languages that haven't yet found a common translator.

The Ego States Present:

	Him	Her
Free Child	Present at the start — the approach is spontaneous, vulnerable, without calculation	Present too — she responds honestly, without strategy
Wounded Child	Beneath the silent withdrawal — the refusal touched something older than tonight	Beneath " <i>are you angry?</i> " — the fear of having hurt, the guilt of being tired
Adapted Submissive Child	"No. Sleep well." — he falls in line, silences what he feels	"I'm really tired" — she minimizes, almost apologizes
Adult	Absent — what he truly feels won't be said tonight	Absent — what she would need isn't named either
Nurturing Parent	—	Variant: sometimes she accepts out of concern for him — not out of desire. Which the other always senses.

What's striking here: both start from the Free Child — spontaneous, open, without calculation. And it's the Wounded Child that takes over, on both sides, in the silence that follows. The Adult — the one who could say "*I sensed you withdraw and I was afraid you were hurt*" or "*when you say no, something closes in me, not anger; more sadness*" — has no place in that moment.

This isn't a lack of maturity. It's the nature of what's happening here. We don't talk about desire from the Adult. We live it from the Child — and that's precisely why the words are missing.

The Karpman Drama Triangle — the Silent Drama

What makes this triangle particular is that it plays out almost entirely in silence. No shouts, no open criticism. And yet the roles are there — active, painful, as real as in the previous scenes.

Act 1 — the approach. He moves closer from a vulnerable place. He's in **Free Child** mode — spontaneous, open, without defense. That moment, before the response, is

perhaps the most exposed of the scene.

Act 2 — the refusal. She says no — gently, honestly. She's not **Persecutor**. She's simply tired. But in the logic of the triangle, her refusal places her, despite herself, in a position where he becomes **Victim** — not rejected violently, but left alone with something he had extended.

Act 3 — the withdrawal. He turns over. This silent withdrawal is a role shift. He slides into passive **Persecutor** — not by intention, but by effect. His silence punishes without saying so. She senses it. And that's what makes her ask "*are you angry?*"

Act 4 — the twist. She asks. She's now in **Victim** mode — guilty of a hurt she didn't want, anxious about the reaction she provoked. He answers "*no, sleep well*" — and becomes the **Rescuer** of facade, the one who says everything's fine so it stops. But both know everything isn't fine.

Free Child (him) → **Victim** of the refusal → Silent **Persecutor** → Her as guilty **Victim** → **Rescuer** of facade (him) → painful silence on both sides

The Hidden Benefit of the Drama

This triangle persists because it protects something — in each person, differently.

For him: not stating the request protects from something even more exposing than the body — the vulnerability of words. As long as the request remains a gesture, a silence, a physical approach, he doesn't have to say what he's truly looking for. And if it's refused, it's the gesture that's refused — not the words. Not what was behind them.

For her: managing the guilt after the refusal is uncomfortable — but it's familiar territory. More familiar, at least, than the conversation about what she needs to want connection. What she would like — to be seen in her tiredness before being desired, to be met without pressure, to find another path toward closeness — is hard to articulate. So she doesn't articulate it. And guilt takes its place.

Both avoid the same thing — not intimacy, but the words that would allow it to be built differently. And that avoidance, repeated, slowly digs the distance that neither wants.

The "Let's You and Him Fight" Game — and Its Silent Version

The game Berne describes under the name "Let's You and Him Fight" takes a particular form here. In its classic version, an external grievance is used to reject an intimate approach — transforming a vulnerability into a power struggle. Sexuality becomes a terrain for negotiation, even punishment.

In this scene, there's no open grievance. But the structure is similar — and more insidious. The conflict doesn't express itself, it deposits. In the silent withdrawal. In the too-short "sleep well." In the eyes open in the dark.

This game has a precise secondary benefit: it allows you to avoid real intimacy — paradoxically — by asking for it or refusing it. Because real intimacy, the one made of true words in the dark, is even more exposing than the body.

The Alert Not to Miss

The exit from this game isn't to make more effort — or to accept when you don't feel like it.

Accepting without real desire doesn't nourish intimacy. It creates a silent debt — on both sides.

The real question for him isn't "how do I get a yes more often?" It's "what am I truly looking for when I move closer — and can I say it differently, or earlier?"

The real question for her isn't "how do I refuse without hurting him?" It's "what do I need to feel available for connection — and do I know that myself?"

These two questions point toward the same place: intimacy isn't an act. It's a state — that we build or let erode, in the daily gestures, well before 11 pm.

What We Really Need — the NVC Angle

In this scene, both are fundamentally looking for the same thing. They look for it from different states, with different strategies — and that's why they miss each other.

The same rule applies in both cases: a need belongs to me. It doesn't depend on what the other person does or doesn't do. I am responsible for finding how to meet it — not for waiting for the other person to guess.

What Both Are Looking For — at Bottom

Read this list. Check what truly resonates — whatever your role in the scene.

Need	What it means for me
Intimacy	I need to be close — truly close, not just in the same bed
Warmth	I need to feel something gentle circulating between us — a gesture, a presence, an attention
Communion	I need a moment that belongs to us — even small, even simple, even silent
Delicacy	I need to be treated with care — in who I am tonight, not in what the other expected
Freedom	I need to be able to express myself — desire or tiredness — without it becoming a fault or a debt

If you're the one who moved closer

Beneath the gesture, there's something you didn't say. And not saying it puts the other in an impossible position — responding in the heat of the moment, from exhaustion, to a request they didn't have time to receive.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Expression	I need to be able to say what I want — not disguise it as a silent gesture that leaves the other guessing
Lightness	I need not to make every approach a test — to let go of the result to stay in the gesture
Courage	I need to allow myself to articulate what I'm looking for — even if it's exposing, even if the response is uncertain

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need expression. What I choose to do is name what I'm looking for earlier in the evening — not at 11 pm in the dark, but in a moment when we're both still available."

"I need lightness. What I choose to do is suggest something gentle without waiting for a precise response — a hug, a closeness, something that asks for nothing but says I'm here."

"I need courage. What I choose to do is say what I'm truly looking for — not necessarily sex, but warmth, connection — and leave the other person free to find how to meet me from where they are."

If you're the one who said no

What you're experiencing isn't rejection. It's a state — exhaustion, a full head, a closed body. A real, legitimate state, that deserves to be named without guilt. And from that state, there might still be something possible — not what was asked for, but something.

Read this list. Check what truly resonates.

Need	What it means for me
Rest	I need to recover — to give myself permission to be exhausted without it becoming a fault
Integrity	I need to act from what I truly feel — not from guilt or obligation
Clarity	I need to know what's possible for me tonight — and to be able to name it, even if it's little

Once your need is identified, complete this sentence:

"I need _____. When I reconnect to this need, what I choose to do is _____."

A few examples:

"I need rest. What I choose to do is give myself permission to be tired — and say it clearly, without apologizing, without minimizing."

"I need integrity. What I choose to do is not accept out of obligation — and not refuse without suggesting something else. Find what's true for me tonight, and say it."

"I need clarity. What I choose to do is ask myself, before the situation arrives, what I need tonight — and name it earlier, when there's still time to find each other differently."

These two lists speak of the same aspiration — being intimate, being close, being treated with delicacy. They don't meet in the scene because nobody found the words at the right moment. But they can meet elsewhere — earlier in the evening, in a space where both are still available to discover together what's possible. Not necessarily what was expected. Perhaps something gentler, simpler — and sometimes, more intimate still.

Feeding Your Free Child

There's a question many readers ask when they arrive at this scene: *how do I get my desire satisfied?*

It's an honest question. But it's looking for the answer in the wrong place.

Desire isn't an end in itself. It's a strategy — a way of looking for something deeper: connection, joy, vitality, the certainty of existing for the other in a way that belongs only to the two of you. And when those needs are nourished elsewhere in daily life — not only in bed, not only in intense moments — desire naturally finds its place again. Or at least, its absence weighs less.

What nourishes those needs isn't spectacular. It's often very simple.

A burst of laughter in the kitchen. A silly joke that only makes the two of you laugh. A pointless surprise — not a gift, just something unexpected that says *I thought of you*. A moment of lightness that's not useful, not productive, not organized around the children or the tasks or the television — just alive. A bit of mischief. A game. Something that steps outside the routine and says *we're still two people who have fun together, not just two adults who manage*.

These moments nourish the Free Child of both. And when the Free Child is nourished — when the day had lightness, connection, shared joy — the body and mind arrive differently at 11 pm. Not necessarily with more desire. But with less distance. Less fatigue with the other. More availability to find each other — one way or another.

The question therefore isn't *how do I get my desire satisfied tonight? It's what did we allow ourselves today — together — that wasn't useful, wasn't obligatory, just for the pleasure of being together?*

The question to ask yourself tonight:

What did we share today that made us smile — or laugh, or surprise us — outside the tasks

and the obligations?

And an additional question, specific to this scene:

If desire is a way of looking for connection — what other paths toward that connection haven't I yet explored?

Paths Toward Intimacy — Beyond Sexuality

Intimacy in a couple doesn't begin in bed. It's built — or eroded — in the gestures that come before. The way you look at each other when you come home. The question asked with real curiosity — not the facade "*did things go well?*" but "*what weighed on you today?*" Physical contact that asks for nothing — a hand placed, a shoulder touched in passing, a forehead kissed without intention.

These gestures nourish something that sexuality alone can't nourish — the certainty of being seen, wanted, held. And they create the conditions in which desire can exist naturally — not as a demand, not as a performance, but as an expression of what's already there.

A few concrete leads — not recipes, directions:

Name what you're looking for, not what you want. Instead of "*do you feel like it?*" — "*I'd love to be close to you tonight.*" The nuance is small. What it opens is different.

Find other paths toward connection. If sexuality is under tension, there are other languages of intimacy — the conversation in the dark, contact without expectation, the shared ritual that says *we're still us*. These paths don't replace desire. They often precede it.

Talk about the subject outside the bedroom. The conversation about desire, the gap, what each needs — it can't happen at 11 pm, in the dark, in the vulnerability of the moment. It needs another space — a Sunday morning, a walk, a moment when both are

available and safe.

Distinguish the refusal of the person from the refusal of the act. Tonight, she said no to something — not to him. This distinction, if it can be said, changes everything that follows.

The Exits

Level 1 — Notice your role in the triangle (solo — both partners)

In the moment, one question:

Am I asking for something — or expressing a need? Am I refusing something — or protecting something?

The difference between asking and expressing a need is real. Asking calls for a yes or a no. Expressing a need opens a conversation.

Level 2 — Name what you're truly looking for (solo — both partners)

Before the approach, before the refusal — an internal question:

What am I truly looking for right now — desire, connection, tenderness? And is this path the only way to get there tonight?

Not to give up what you're looking for. To see if there's another path — less exposing, more accessible in this precise moment.

Level 3 — Say what you need earlier (solo — both partners)

What's missing in this scene is a conversation that could have happened earlier. Not a negotiation — a simple opening.

"I'd love it if we had a moment together tonight."

That sentence, said in the evening, changes everything that follows. It leaves the other time to respond from an available place — not from 11 pm exhaustion. And it opens the possibility of finding each other differently — a hug, a closeness, something gentle that

asks for nothing but says **we're still us**.

Level 4 — Build intimacy rituals (together — to explore together)

A conversation to have calmly, outside the bedroom, outside any recent tension:

"What makes you feel close to me — truly close, not just present? And what creates distance, even without conflict?"

Not to decide on a program. To know each other better on this terrain — and give yourselves leads that don't go exclusively through sexuality.

Level 5 — Talk about the subject directly (together)

This is the most difficult conversation — and the most useful. Not in the moment of tension. Not after a refusal. In a neutral, available, safe space.

"I realize we never really talk about this — about what we're looking for, about what we're missing, about what creates distance between us on this subject. And I think it's costing us something. Can we talk about it?"

Not a confrontation. An opening — from the Adult, addressed to the other's Adult. With the awareness that this subject demands more gentleness than any other.

Tracking — 7 Days

Every evening, 2 minutes.

Day	I nourished intimacy other than through sexuality	I named what I was looking for — to myself first	I nourished my Free Child (what?)
Monday	☐	☐	
Tuesday	☐	☐	
Wednesday	☐	☐	
Thursday	☐	☐	
Friday	☐	☐	
Saturday	☐	☐	
Sunday	☐	☐	

The evening question:

Monday: *Today, how did I create connection with the other — other than through sexuality?*

Tuesday: *When I sought closeness, what path did I take — and was it the most suited to that moment?*

Wednesday: *What could I have said earlier today — and kept to myself?*

Thursday: *At what moment did I feel we were truly close today — and what created that?*

Friday: *How did I nourish my Free Child today — and what did it change in my availability for the other?*

Saturday: *What belief about desire or sexuality do I carry — and where does it come from?*

Sunday: *If intimacy were no longer under tension between us — what would an ordinary evening look like?*

Duo Version — Exchange in 2 Parts

To do in a moment of lightness and connection already present — not after a tension, not when tired. 20 minutes, in a space where both feel safe.

Part 1 — Our Languages of Intimacy (10 minutes)

Each person completes these sentences separately, in writing:

"What makes me feel truly close to you is..." "What creates distance between us, even without conflict, is..." "What I would need more often to feel intimate with you — not necessarily sexually — is..."

Then you share — each person reads, the other listens without interrupting, without correcting, without suggesting. The goal isn't to find a solution. It's to hear what intimacy truly means for the other — not what we assumed.

Part 2 — A Gesture (10 minutes)

One question to explore together:

"What is one concrete gesture — small, daily, accessible — that would tell the other person they matter to me in a way that belongs to them?"

Not a program. Not a solemn promise. Just a gesture — to try this week, to adjust, to keep if it does something.

One Last Thing

This booklet has traversed six scenes. Arguments about dishes, late returns, difficult calls, overspent budgets, resistant homework, silent nights.

None of these scenes was really about what it seemed to be.

The household tasks were about who carries what — and why. The late return was about the need to exist for the other. The call with her mother was about being heard, not advised. The money was about freedom and trust. The homework was about legitimacy and history. And this last scene — perhaps the simplest of all in its form, perhaps the most charged in its substance — was about one thing: *do I matter to you, in a way that belongs only to us?*

It's not a question we ask. It's a question we play — in the silences, the withdrawals, the taking back of control, the unsolicited solutions, the nights with eyes open in the dark.

This booklet doesn't resolve this question. It offers something more modest and more useful: to begin seeing it. Because seeing a game is already being less entirely its prisoner.

What comes next — if you want to go further — is the conversation. The one that hasn't happened yet. The one that begins with *"I'm going to tell you something that's hard to put into words"* — and that happens in a moment when both are ready to hear.

That moment, only you can choose.

Furthermore, while I truly want you to become self-reliant in this quest for an *"improved"* relationship, it's often very difficult to resolve these issues while being deeply involved in the relationship yourself. External support is often a way to gain awareness and make the discussion more amicable. Please feel free to contact me to discuss this further or to receive guidance. I would be happy to respond.